AP US History — Course Overview

Class 1 reference handout

Source: Adapted from the College Board AP United States History Course and Exam Description (collegeboard.org).

The AP U.S. History course is organized into nine historical periods that span from 1491 to the present. Students develop seven historical thinking skills and reasoning processes that they will apply on the AP Exam in May. This handout previews the structure of the course and the exam so you know what to expect across the year.

Connect: This is your roadmap for the year. As you scan the nine periods, notice which eras you already know something about and which are unfamiliar — those unfamiliar ones will demand extra study time when we get there.

Key Passages

The Nine Periods

Period 1: 1491–1607 · Period 2: 1607–1754 · Period 3: 1754–1800 · Period 4: 1800–1848 · Period 5: 1844–1877 · Period 6: 1865–1898 · Period 7: 1890–1945 · Period 8: 1945–1980 · Period 9: 1980–present.

The Seven Themes

American & National Identity (NAT) · Work, Exchange & Technology (WXT) · Geography & the Environment (GEO) · Migration & Settlement (MIG) · Politics & Power (PCE) · America in the World (WOR) · American & Regional Culture (ARC) · Social Structures (SOC).

Historical Reasoning Skills

Contextualization · Comparison · Causation · Continuity and Change Over Time (CCOT). Plus skills: Identify and explain historical developments, Analyze sourcing & situation, Analyze claims & evidence in sources, Analyze patterns & connections, Make and support an argument.

Exam Format (May)

Section I: 55 multiple-choice questions (55 min) + 3 short-answer questions (40 min). Section II: 1 Document-Based Question (60 min, incl. 15-min reading) + 1 Long Essay Question (40 min). Total exam time: 3 hours 15 minutes.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Which of the seven themes do you find most interesting going in? Which feels least familiar?

2. Knowing the exam format, which task (MCQ, SAQ, DBQ, LEQ) do you most want to practice this year?

3. Set one academic goal for APUSH that you can measure by November.